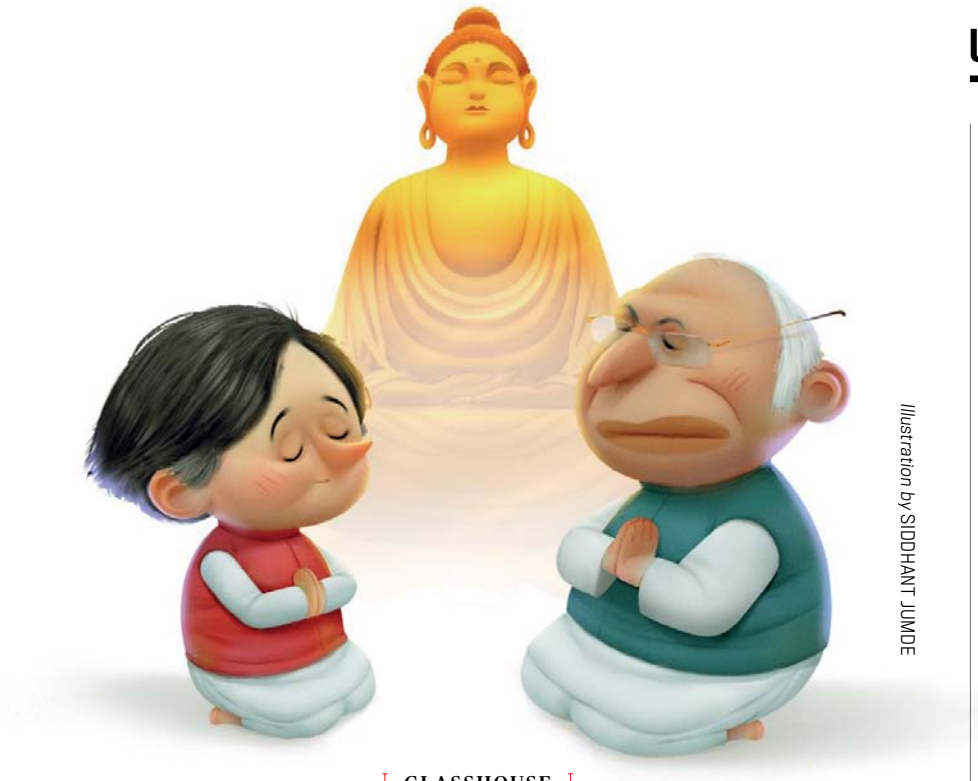


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE LOTUS SUTRA

It seems the two candidates for the Congress presidential election—Mallikarjun Kharge and Shashi Tharoor—bank heavily on the divine blessings of Lord Buddha. The octogenarian Kharge is a self-professed Buddhist and has often said that Buddhism is one of the best ways to achieve peace and harmony in society. Tharoor began his campaign for the election on October 1 with a visit to the Deekshabhoomi monument in Nagpur. Deekshabhoomi is where Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar, the founding father of our Constitution, converted to Buddhism along with his followers in 1956. The two will have to wait till October 19 to know on whom the Buddha finally smiles.

The Doval Hand

National Security Advisor **Ajit Doval**'s imprint was evident in the nationwide crackdown on the Popular Front of India (PFI), and the appointment of Lt Gen. Anil Chauhan as the new Chief of Defence Staff (CDS). If PFI was most active in the former IPS officer's cadre state Kerala, Chauhan comes from his home state Uttarakhand. Doval single-handedly anchored the multiagency operation against the PFI. He is also pushing the BJP government to reach out to moderate Muslim outfits as a counter-balance. Chauhan's post-retirement assignment as military advisor to the Doval-led National Security Council Secretariat helped the three-star officer, junior in rank to the service chiefs, get an additional star and a position above these officers.





SINGING RETORT

Ragini Sonker, 32, the Samajwadi Party MLA from Uttar Pradesh's Machhalishahar seat, has set the House and social media afire with her musical speeches. In the just concluded session, she sang Kishore *da*'s *Kuchh to log kahenge* to talk of women's empowerment. Its video got millions of hits on social media. Even Opposition BJP praised Sonker, an MBBS from Kolkata and an ophthalmology major from AIIMS, Delhi.

Kaushik Deka with Prashant Srivastava, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava and Kiran D. Tare



A NEW LINE OF TREATMENT

If conducting surprise midnight checks on government hospitals was not enough, Bihar deputy CM **Tejashwi Yadav**, who also holds the health portfolio, has now started responding to Twitter messages by common citizens seeking hospital beds. He is not only arranging beds but also seeking feedback on the treatment provided. The cricketer-turned-politician has given a 60-day deadline to health officials to improve performance. Incidentally, elder brother Tej Pratap Yadav held the health portfolio in the previous *mahagathbandhan* government between November 2015 and July 2017.

SuperCM

The Eknath Shinde-led Maharashtra government may have recently transferred 44 babus in its first major reshuffle after wresting power in June, but it had deputy CM **Devendra Fadnavis**'s stamp all over. He not only got the controversial retired bureaucrat V.K. Gautam out, but also ensured his men—Praveen Darade, Vivek Bhimanvar, Milind Borikar, Ashwini Joshi, Dipendra-sinh Kushwaha—got plum posts. Shinde managed to get his favourite Ashok Shingare as collector of Thane, his home district. Surprisingly, Mumbai municipal commissioner I.S. Chahal remained untouched despite his proximity to the Thackerays.



MANDAR DEODHAR